

UNIT BRIEF

Unit code & title	25-DFT101 (full-time) Independent Research Project: Proposal
Programme title School	MDes Design Futures, School of Design
Academic Year	2025/26
Delivery term	2FT & 2PT
Credits	15
Unit leads	Dr Ravi Sikhwal and Dr Žaneta Muranko

UNIT LEARNING OUTCOMES

Upon successful completion of this unit, you will be expected to be able to:

- Identify a design futures topic that addresses an environmental and/or societal challenge, including situating the topic and its significance in relation to existing work and developing an appropriate research question;
- Propose a design futures project, including the application of relevant approaches and methods.

UNIT DELIVERABLES AND DEADLINES

Below is a list of unit deliverables, alongside a unit schedule in Table 1. Each of the deliverables is detailed on the following pages.

Preparation (see p. 4)

1. Topic Proposal - Presentation and Discussion
 - Slides due using template provided in shared Google file: Wednesday, January 28, 9:00
 - Individual presentations and discussion: scheduled throughout Wednesday, January 28
2. Visual Annotated Literature and Practice Review
 - Link or file shared on Moodle: Tuesday, March 24, 9:00
3. IRP Research Ethics

In-class work (p.5)

4. Group and individual tutorials, trends workshop participation and peer reviews
 - Material prepared for discussion: weekly

Formative Assessment (p.5)

5. Critique Presentation (Exhibition Style)
 - 5-minute presentation: Tuesday, April 14

Summative Assessment (p.5-6)

6. Independent Research Project: Proposal
 - Report as pdf on Moodle and emailed to your peer reviewer: Tuesday, May 5, 09:00
7. Peer Review
 - Oral feedback in tutorials and critiques
 - Written feedback on someone else's report as pdf on Moodle: Friday, May 8, 09:00

Unit Schedule

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Week of 8 Dec		Pre-IRP Proposal Briefing 15:00-16:00			
Week of 26 Jan			IRP Proposal - Topic Presentations 10:00-15:00		
Week of 9 Feb				IRP Proposal - Trend Wall Workshop 1 10:00-13:00	
Week of 16 Feb			Staff Pecha Kucha 10:00-10:45 Next 4 weeks - Recap 10:45 - 11:00 1h Group Tutorials 11:00-14:00 Optional workshop on IRP Audiences and Impacts 15:00 - 16:00		
Week of 9 March		IRP Proposal - Trend Wall Workshop 2 10:00-12:30			
Week of 23 March		Deadline: Literature and Practice Review Draft 1 09:00 Briefing- IRP proposal 10:00-11:00 Alumni Panel 11:00-12:30	1h Group Tutorial - 'Hero' Object, Discussion of Literature and Practice Review <i>The schedule will be shared</i>	Optional Tutor Drop-in <i>The schedule will be shared</i> Optional Future Friends event, evening in the Art Bar	Optional Tutor Drop-in <i>The schedule will be shared</i>
Week of 30 March	Futures Approaches Conference Day 1 10:00-15:30 <i>The schedule will be shared</i> Deadline: Literature and Practice Review Draft 2, 09:00	Futures Approaches Conference Day 2 10:00-15:30 <i>The schedule will be shared</i>	1h Group Tutorial: Approach and Methodology <i>The schedule will be shared</i>	Easter break	Easter break
Week of 6 April	Easter break	Easter break	Individual Tutorial: 15 min check-ins <i>The schedule will be shared</i>	1h Group Tutorial: Methodology Deadline: Methodology Draft 1 to present at tutorial <i>The schedule will be shared</i>	
Week of 13 April		Crit: Exhibition Style 10:00-17:00 <i>The schedule will be shared</i>			

*Please note that the times listed in the table are subject to change. Any changes will be communicated by the tutors prior to the session.

What is a Design Futures project?

A Design Futures project:

1. **Addresses long-term, complex, societal and/or environmental challenges.** This can include current and emerging systemic problems that you want to prevent or address in the future (for example, working now to avoid +2 degrees in the future, or anticipating and dealing with the consequences of climate change in the future). It is up to you to define what **long-term** means in the context of your project, considering the change you wish to initiate, the stakeholders and sector you are focusing on, and the form of your intervention (e.g., consider the implementation time of a community-led initiative vs. a new policy). However, projects should avoid issues that can be 'solved' in the short-term.
2. **Envisions alternative futures with the aim of creating preferable, sustainable futures.** By creating different scenarios, you will communicate multiple potential futures to help stakeholders imagine and navigate towards one or more preferable futures. You can explore preposterous, possible, plausible, projected, and probable futures to challenge existing narratives and highlight opportunities or risks that may not yet be apparent. However, the overall project should build toward the **preferable futures** you define. These should envision a better world, centred around social and environmental goals like sustainability, health, equity, equality, justice, and well-being. Preferable futures serve as guides for decision-making, policies, and actions aimed at creating desirable outcomes. In defining a preferable future, you should demonstrate that you have considered multiple futures, explain for whom the selected future is preferable, and justify and critically reflect on your decisions, biases and ethical considerations.
3. **Is based on a clear methodology and design futures approach.** It applies research, design and futures methods and theories, and reflects on why they are appropriate to the project as well as their limitations. It references established methods and approaches, illustrating critical awareness of how others are working in this field.
4. **Is transdisciplinary but design-led.** The project takes a holistic approach to understand complex challenges, involving diverse sources of expertise and approaches. Design is used to combine academic and non-academic knowledge (e.g., indigenous, local, practical), connecting disciplines, lived experiences and design frameworks. At the same time, the role of design is clearly defined – it should be evident why this is a *design* futures project.
5. **Is inclusive.** The project involves others in generating, negotiating and validating ideas. It recognises a variety of perspectives on the topic and in defining preferable futures.
6. **Is grounded in research and critical thinking.** The project draws on a range of research sources to ask critical questions, understand the complexity and root causes of the challenge, and build evidence-based scenarios.
7. **Is positioned within a well-defined futures context.** This is based on your primary and secondary research, including signals, trends, drivers and emerging futures. You will define a systems-level perspective (human / society / nature / technology), temporal scales (short / medium / long / very long / century) and models (e.g., cyclical, linear, ecological), contextual scales (macro / meso / micro), and any other models appropriate to the challenge and change you propose.
8. **Is designed to make change and to have an impact.** The project describes pathways to achieve preferable futures, and anticipates impacts and long-term change that could result. It employs appropriate formats to reach stakeholders who can help to create preferable futures.

1. Topic Proposal - Presentation & Discussion

Submission Details (Shared on December 9, 2025)

Deliverables: 9 slides and 5 minute oral presentation.

Deadline: Slides submission by Wednesday, January 28, 9:00,

Presentations: Wednesday, January 28, 10:00 - 15:00

Format: In-person oral presentation (5min) followed by a feedback session (10min). Presentations developed using the provided **slide template** ( IRP Topic_template), as outlined below:

Slide 1: You - name, email, headshot, and your topic in 5 words or less

Slide 2: Mind map or similar diagram summarising different directions you explored

Slide 3: Topic - what it is, why it's important and how you know it's important

Slide 4: Why it is a futures topic - what is the long-term, complex, societal and/or environmental challenge you wish to address, what are the trends and drivers

Slide 5: what are the trends and drivers

Slide 6: Next steps - plan for conducting your literature and practice review including research questions to guide you

Slide 7: Questions for tutors - what you need feedback on

Slide 8: Reference list (you need to share insight during your presentation)

Slide 9: Preliminary Ethics Checklist, plans for ethics approval (Check Moodle for Ethics Details including checklist)

2. Visual Annotated Literature and Practice Review

Submission Details (Shared on December 9, 2025 and February 9, 2026)

Deliverables: Visual annotated literature and practice review with research questions, problem framing and representative object.

Version 1

Deadline: Tuesday, 24th March, 2026, 9:00, on Moodle.

Format: Visual research board to be submitted on Moodle as a pdf or link to a digital file (e.g., Miro, Figma board).

****Be prepared to discuss and reflect on your review during the week of 24 March.**

The following requirements are detailed on [Moodle](#):

1. Visual Annotated Literature and Practice Review
2. Research Questions and Conclusion
3. Problem Framing
4. Three-Dimensional Object Representing Your Topic (To bring along during IRP proposal tutorial on 25th March)

This background research, together with your initial research questions and project framing, feed directly into the IRP Proposal Report.

Version 2

Deadline: Monday, 30th March, 2026, 9:00, on Moodle.

Format: First draft of text for sections 1-3 of the IRP Proposal Report, submitted on Moodle as a pdf.

3. IRP Research Ethics

The research ethics are designed to protect the rights, privacy, and welfare of participants and their personal data, minimise risks to participants, researchers, and the institution, and strengthen the quality of research. The [Taught Student Ethics](#) Committee oversees student research projects. Any research involving humans or other living beings, such as interviews, surveys, workshops, photography, video recording, or observation, requires ethics clearance.

Students must complete an [ethics checklist](#) (first version before group tutorial on 18th Feb and second version before group tutorial on 24th March), after which they receive an email indicating whether their project is classified as low, medium, or high risk; this result is confidential and the checklist can be completed multiple times. If the project is low risk, students must complete the ethics checklist and submit them to their tutor, and address any requested revisions before receiving approval to proceed. If the project is medium or high risk, students are encouraged to discuss with their tutor whether it can be adapted to become low risk. Otherwise, a [full application](#) must be submitted to the Taught Student Ethics Committee. After receiving committee approval, students must share the approved application and related correspondence with their tutor before beginning their research in the IRP realisation unit.

4. Tutorials and Workshops

Everyone has been assigned a tutor for this unit. In addition to the individual presentations, group tutorials and trend workshops from January-March, this unit includes group tutorials, an individual tutorial, a mini conference, a group critique (exhibition) and optional drop-ins with other tutors. Schedules and instructions will be provided for each.

5. Critique

Submission Details

Deliverables: Display materials as described below

Deadline: Tuesday, 14th April, 10:00

Mode: Exhibition, discussion

Format: Tabletop display and informal presentation, plus a record of displayed materials and feedback included in the IRP Proposal Report

You will present the latest version of your IRP proposal in an exhibition-style format. Your work should be communicated through curated materials displayed in the space, allowing tutors and peers to engage with your project through conversation and exploration. You will discuss your project with tutors and peers who are unfamiliar with your work, and give feedback to others.

Deliverables:

- **First draft of your report (A4, printed)** following the IRP Report Template and including whatever content you have developed so far. You are encouraged to design the layout and visually communicate your work.
- **Hero image with project title and your name (A3, printed).** 'Hero' is used here as a metaphor for something that wins someone's attention and represents your project. It must be your original work.
- **3-d object representing your topic.** Can be the same as you showed March 24.
- **5 different postcards or similar (printed)** to be used as conversation prompts. Must include:
 - images
 - project title
 - research question(s)

- problem framing
- key research insights
- overview of methodology
- any other information from the report that you wish to discuss in the critique
- Anything else you feel is necessary to communicate and get feedback on your proposal. If you are exploring your topic through methods such as making, collecting materials or artifacts, experimenting with diegetic prototypes, or other forms of inquiry, you are strongly encouraged to include these in your exhibition.

6. Independent Research Project: Proposal

Submission Details

Deliverables: Part 1 of the IRP Report following the template provided on Moodle.

Deadline: Tuesday, May 5, 2026, 09:00

Mode: Individual submission, one digital copy submitted on Moodle through Turnitin.

Format: **Written report** to be submitted as a PDF. It should be approximately 2500 - 3500 words long (plus references), with illustrations as appropriate.

In this unit, students complete Part 1 of the IRP Report using the provided outline. Part 2 will be covered during the IRP Realisation unit. It is an evolving document that follows the development of your project and is submitted in its entirety at the conclusion of Term 3.

The goals of Part 1 of the IRP Report - Proposal are:

- Justify your design futures topic in relation to your review of literature, practice and trends, providing clarity on the significance of the topic within the broader context of future environmental and/or societal challenges
- Frame the challenge (problem) space you are working with
- Critically reflect on the role of design and design futures in your project, clearly positioning yourself and your work
- Propose a plan to completion for the IRP, including methodology, milestones and potential outcomes

7. Peer Review

Formal peer review requirements involve:

- Active participation in tutorials
- Verbal feedback at critiques on April 14
- Written feedback on 1 other IRP report, to be submitted on Moodle and emailed to the student whose work you are reviewing

Deadline: Friday May 8, 2026, 09:00

Mode: Individual submission, one digital copy submitted on Moodle

Format: One page PDF.

A template will be provided to record your peer feedback.

AI, REFERENCING AND PLAGIARISM

This is your research, your brain, your writing. Use of AI to improve writing is acceptable, but generating new texts is not acceptable for this work. The work must demonstrate your original thinking and your voice. If AI plays a role in your project, please review the RCA's recommendations

(<https://intranet.rca.ac.uk/support/it-services/using-generative-ai-at-the-royal-college-of-art/>) and reflect on your use in the *Use of AI in Assessment - disclosure statement*. In your IRP Proposal

report.

Academic conventions must be observed. All sources, including visuals, must be acknowledged and accurately cited through proper quotations and in-text citations. Every sentence where you have used an idea or fact that is not your own (i.e. something you learned through your research) must include the source(s) at the end of that sentence. Direct quotations must be in quotation marks and also include the page number. Sources must appear in the reference list at the end. Use the Harvard Referencing System. The RCA library provides a guide to help you with this process - <https://rca.libguides.com/harvard/intro>

Plagiarism will not be tolerated. Everything must be written in your own words. If you copy text directly from another source, it must be in quotation marks, and it must be introduced in your own words. The best practice is to paraphrase with limited quotations. You can read more about plagiarism in points 6 and 7 of the Student Academic Misconduct Policy:
<https://rca-media2.rca.ac.uk/documents/4. Student Academic Misconduct Policy Revised 2022.pdf>